# Stephen Dossou

Mines Paris – PSL, CERNA
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Citizenship: Benin

## Research Fields

**Primary:** Entrepreneurial Finance, Venture Capital
**Secondary:** Contract Theory and Mechanism Design, Applied Econometrics

## Education

**Ph.D. in Economics, Mines Paris – PSL (CERNA, ED SDOSE)** 2024 – expected 2027
Advisors: Pierre Fleckinger and Philippe Mustar

**Diplôme d'Ingénieur (M.Sc. equivalent), CentraleSupélec** 2020 – 2024
Information & Communication Engineering. Optimization, machine learning, network theory, quantitative modelling.

**Classes Préparatoires (MPSI, MP*), Lycée Louis-le-Grand, Paris** 2018 – 2020
Competitive undergraduate programme in advanced mathematics and physics.

## Visiting Positions

**Visiting Ph.D. Student, Imperial College Business School, London** Oct. – Nov. 2026
Host: Ramana Nanda (scheduled).

## Honors and Awards

**Ranked 1st nationwide, *Baccalauréat* série C (science track), Benin** 2017

**Ranked 1st nationwide, *BEPC* (lower-secondary national examination), Benin** 2014

## Job Market Paper

**"Protection and Dilution: SAFEs and MFN Clauses in Seed Financing"**

I ask how an accelerator should protect its stake against the seed investor who finances its startups next, and what a most-favored-nation (MFN) clause, such as the $375,000 uncapped MFN SAFE that Y Combinator added to its standard deal in 2022, is worth to it. In my model, the accelerator spends its contribution before a liquidity shock, a seed investor with market power covers the rest with a priced or an unpriced SAFE, and competitive investors fund the projects worth scaling. Without protection, the seed investor takes all the equity of the projects it finances. A fixed post-money share gives the accelerator this share of every project the seed investor finances. When the accelerator invests, an MFN component strictly beats any fixed share: it takes more from small rounds than from large ones, and the seed investor answers with a capped SAFE and invests beyond its need in the smallest rounds. Numerically, the clause gives the highest profit and the highest total surplus for software-like projects. For deep-tech projects, the accelerator invests nothing, and its fixed share lowers the total surplus to

about three quarters of the first best. *JEL:* G24, G23, D86.

## WORKING PAPERS

**"Pooling Contracts between Venture Capital Institutions"** (with Pierre Fleckinger)

- Venture capital contracts are bargained deal by deal with entrepreneurs, but contracts between institutions are not: an accelerator committing to a venture capitalist, or a venture capitalist committing to a limited partner, faces non-negotiable terms and often commits blind. In an informed-principal framework, when the principal reveals the project's expected outcome *after* the investor has committed — the LP-to-VC relationship — an optimal pooling mechanism exists and the budget constraint is slack in cash-rich economies, so every profitable project is financed. When revelation comes *before* the commitment — the accelerator-to-VC relationship — the unique optimal mechanism is again pooling, but the budget constraint binds in every economy and some positive-NPV projects are necessarily excluded. The observed uniformity of institutional terms is therefore an equilibrium object rather than an administrative convenience. *JEL:* G24, G23, D82, D86.

**"Avoiding the British: Brexit and Partner Choice in European Venture Capital"**

- Nothing in the UK's withdrawal restricted co-investment, yet continental venture capitalists whose pre-determined reliance on British partners was above the median cut the share of their syndicates including a British investor by 8.2 percentage points against a base rate of 18.7% ($p < 0.001$), from the semester of the referendum onwards. The effect is confined to the relational margin: deal counts, stages, round sizes, follow-on financing and exits are all null, established British ties dissolve no faster than comparable continental ones (triple difference $+0.3$ pp, $p = 0.77$), and aggregate UK–continental volume tracks the rest of Europe. Exposure-based event study on Crunchbase, wild-cluster bootstrap inference.

## POLICY REPORTS

**"Devenir ETI : les chemins de la croissance"** June 2025
with Pierre Fleckinger, Philippe Mustar and Antoine Prévet.
Chaire etilab, Mines Paris – PSL. Report on the growth of French SMEs into mid-sized firms, based on statistical analysis of INSEE's FARE firm-level accounting files, accessed through the CASD.

## PRESENTATIONS

EARIE (European Association for Research in Industrial Economics), Mannheim August 2026
*Pooling Contracts between Venture Capital Institutions*

Internal doctoral workshop, Mines Paris – PSL (CERNA) July 2026
*Avoiding the British: Brexit and Partner Choice in European Venture Capital*

IOEA (Institute of Organizational Economics Academy), Cargèse April 2026
*Pooling Contracts between Venture Capital Institutions*

Journée des Doctorants (joint with Université Paris-Dauphine), Mines Paris – PSL March 2026
*Pooling Contracts between Venture Capital Institutions*

## Teaching

**Microeconomics (undergraduate, first-year engineering cycle)** 2024 – 2026
Teaching assistant (*travaux dirigés*), Mines Paris – PSL. Two academic years (2024–2025, 2025–2026); 6 hours of tutorials per year plus exam grading.

## Professional Experience

**Research Assistant, Mines Paris – PSL** Jan. 2024 – Oct. 2024
Research on startups and mid-sized firms in France; construction and analysis of large firm-level financial datasets.

**Business Analyst (apprenticeship), Forvia** Sept. 2022 – Jan. 2024
Digital transformation initiatives in an industrial environment; operational monitoring tools.

**Marketing Analyst (internship), Manda** Sept. 2021 – Jan. 2022
Acquisition strategy and performance analytics.

**Data Scientist (internship), Onogone** July – Aug. 2021
Development and evaluation of NLP models.

## Skills

**Methods:** Panel and event-study designs, difference-in-differences and triple differences, wild-cluster bootstrap inference with few clusters, falsification and placebo protocols, mechanism design and optimal control.

**Software:** Python, R, LaTeX, Matlab.

**Data:** Crunchbase; construction of investor–round and dyad-level panels (>1.2M investor–round observations). Security clearance for confidential statistical data (*habilitation au secret statistique*) and accredited user of the CASD (*Centre d'accès sécurisé aux données*); work on INSEE's FARE firm-level accounting files.

## Languages

French (native), English (C1).

## References

**Pierre Fleckinger**
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**Philippe Mustar**
Professor, Mines Paris – PSL (CERNA) — philippe.mustar@minesparis.psl.eu

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